



Invest India

India ranked ninth most attractive investment destination by a recent UN report. Meanwhile govt. approved FDI proposals worth Rs. 2,245.32 crore

4 Are you a teacher's pet?

While a lot of us have started complaining about our declining education system, there are still tens of millions who would kill to go to your run-of-the-mill, everyday "sub-standard" school. That's not to say that the education system couldn't use a shot in the arm, and technology has all the right nutrients for a magical growth serum. Of course, when we talk about education and India, we're not talking about just improving the quality of education, but also improving the quantity of students who have access to it. We'd also love to see a law that makes it mandatory for kids to (at least) be educated till class 10. Get them out of those carpet producing factories and kitchens and into classrooms – physical, virtual, whatever. As for parents who don't send their kids to free schools, deny them loans of all kinds, the right to vote, and put a few repeat offenders in jail, if need be. As you can tell this is something we feel strongly about, and accept no excuses for.

Solution: R.O.S.E.S.

What we need is an open source education system. In our case, the Required Open Source Education System.

Short, simple, but oh so sweet. You just can't go wrong with such a system. Much like Wikipedia and social networking, it's just the need of the hour for some transparency and openness in schools.

How it could work

Assuming that the Cumulo-Indus is built, a simple starting point could be



The e-lab at the Institute of Lifelong Learning, Delhi University

to make it mandatory for all existing schools to teach as many free students as those that pay fees. With voice and video not really technology that's out of reach, we could make it mandatory for all schools to run virtual classroom programs. However, while the Cumulo-Indus could solve the problem of reaching children across India and teaching them, this is a solution for the quantity of education provided, not the quality.

The ordinary

Here's where the open source solution could kick in. With the Cumulo-Indus already providing a way to connect and store data collectively, what we'd need next is a central hub for knowledge – perhaps for each state, in case we can't invent the Babel-babble in time, or centralised if we do.

Think about the amount of knowledge sharing that can be achieved. With videos of lectures, and sharing of notes, there'd be no excuse of bad teachers anymore, because if you didn't get what your teacher was saying, or didn't like his or her teaching style, you could choose to take that course virtually from a teacher across the country whose style suited your own learning style. You could also just opt for virtual extra classes in subjects you find yourself struggling with.

The extraordinary

Although the effort here is to gather all knowledge that we can and make it accessible to students of schools, colleges and researchers alike, the idea is not to make the same mistakes again. A lot of experts have been saying that what we need is a way to do away with grading systems, and neatly categorising kids from young

ages according to grades. We need to encourage diversity in thinking and learning, so the current system of grading will have to go. You can't categorise kids based on how good or bad they are at math, science, commerce and the likes. Instead we will need to encourage them to pursue streams that interest them, and not discourage interests because they don't fall into our neatly organised job classifications.

Although we're focussed on India, it's not like we'd be averse to schools and colleges around the world logging in to Cumulo-Indus and sharing our knowledge, whilst imparting some of their own. Perhaps the Cumulo-Indus could expand its boundaries, and take over the world, without the mad scientist laugh track being played in the background.

What incentives would the businessmen behind schools and colleges have left to run them? Well, they wouldn't stop making money, they'd just help India



Colleges in Second-life are just so much cooler looking, aren't they?

more than usual. Plus, there could be incentive schemes given to those schools and colleges that have the most used lectures. Schemes such as compute time on the Cumulo-Indus for the school/college labs that are researching and trying to build the most needed innovations – give the Babel-babble more CPU time please!

Must-clicks

<http://bit.ly/I0UvI> | <http://bit.ly/14LXs> | <http://bit.ly/dCh0c6>